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Anthropologizing Afghanistan: Colonial and Postcolonial Encounters

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Abstract

Afghanistan is a key region in and from which scholars can reflect on the potentials and challenges of anthropology. Structured chronologically and analytically, this review analyzes the persistence up to present day of the colonial image of an inward-looking society without, however, equating the current interplay of states and nonstate actors to the international context of the nineteenth century or the Cold War. The 1960s and 1970s were a productive period for research on the country focusing on pastoral nomadism, ethnicity, state, and tribe. When the opportunity for long-term fieldwork in Afghanistan was temporarily interrupted in the 1980s with the Soviet occupation, anthropologists were forced to shift focus. Many worked among Afghan refugees in Pakistan as well as on the diaspora, including on the transnational networks of migrants. The international intervention in late 2001 incited an academic scramble for Afghanistan. The article reflects on the deontological challenges of research in an environment characterized by the demand for immediate policy-relevant knowledge while arguing that the study of the overlapping sovereignties linked to the interplay of international and nongovernmental organizations with the state and military forces in Afghanistan contribute to larger current debates in anthropology.

INTRODUCTION: THE AFGHAN CRISIS IN THE MIRROR OF ANTHROPOLOGY

Afghanistan is variably considered by politicians and scholars to be part of the Middle East, Central Asia, or South Asia. Often considered a crossroads, as though it were not a location in its own right but instead a triple periphery, Afghanistan seems to escape conventional divisions of the world into discrete areas. It has been classified among the least peaceful countries, and development indicators show it as having among the highest infant mortality rates and one of the lowest life expectancy rates in the world. Although a poor and war-torn country, Afghanistan is anything but marginal. The global effects of the crises of its polity, economy, and society seem to parallel the country's central location on the Mercator's projection.

During the nineteenth century, the Afghan polity was at the heart of the Great Game, the strategic rivalry between the British and Russian empires for supremacy in West and Central Asia. The bitter war waged during the 1980s between the Afghan central government, which was backed by the Soviet Union, and the resistance, which was sponsored by the West, played a major role in the last period of the Cold War. It can be seen as yet another chapter in the struggle for super-power supremacy in the region. More recently, the intervention of the US-led military coalition and the fall of the Taliban in late 2001 have brought about further transformations with global ramifications. In addition to its geostrategic significance, the Afghan conflict has caused one of the gravest humanitarian disasters in recent history.

Conventional accounts of its current predicament emphasize the resilience of tradition in the face of modernity, the persistence of tribalism and ethnic loyalties, the rise of Islamic fundamentalism, international terrorism, drug trafficking, and corruption. But these explanations tend to reproduce the paradigm of the modernization theory, with its predictable stages of progress, just as they mirror the normative protocols of peace- and nation-building that have inspired the international community's reconstruction effort since 2001. In an environment so saturated by the demand for immediate policy-relevant knowledge, what role might anthropology with its tradition of ethnography based on long-term immersion and a critique of Eurocentrism play? In a country that has been profoundly and irremediably transformed by the lasting presence of foreign troops and aid organizations, where almost everybody—man or woman, adult or child, rich or poor—has been displaced, is there still room for the sense of locality and prolonged fieldwork supposed to distinguish anthropological scholarship from other varieties of knowledge production?

The old trope of an inward-looking society persists irrespective of the country's past and present economic, political, religious, and cultural ties beyond its borders. And yet Afghanistan today cannot be understood in terms of a struggle between two external powers that characterized its situation during the colonial period and the Cold War. A formal democracy with an elected president and parliament, the country depends almost fully on foreign assistance for its security and the delivery of basic social services. However, perhaps nowhere else are the moral and political virtues of human rights and democracy more vehemently contested than in Afghanistan. It may thus be a useful vantage point from which to disrupt the telos of modernity, an arena for diverging moralities where social and political processes common elsewhere in Asia, Africa, and Latin America—such as massive displacement of populations, political violence, external interventions, and humanitarian aid—may be observed in a heightened form. The specificity of the country could arguably lie in this volatile mixture, the analysis of which could contribute to larger debates in anthropology over entangled modernities (Randeria 2006) and fuzzy sovereignties (Monsutti 2012).

Structured chronologically and analytically, this article reviews the directions of past and present anthropological research in and on Afghanistan. It also addresses the deontological

challenges of research in a place where international and nongovernmental organizations (IOs and NGOs, respectively) as well as armed forces provide more jobs for social scientists than do academic institutions.

IOs: international organizations

NGOs: nongovernmental organizations

AFGHANISTAN AND THE COLONIAL IMAGINATION

In the nineteenth century Afghanistan became a colonial trope. Scholars, diplomatic emissaries, political agents, adventurers, and travelers gave numerous accounts of the country's tumultuous politics (Burnes 1986, Elphinstone 1992, Masson 1997, among others). The British gazetteers reported on social organization, tribal structures, military alliances, and economic activities (recompiled by Adamec 1972–1985). These authors were actors in the imperial rivalry of their time and thus were involved, in one way or another, in the colonial enterprise. The knowledge they produced went hand in hand with power. And indeed these reports reflect not only the firsthand experiences of these men but also often their remarkably erudite understanding of the region. The cultural immersion and linguistic competences of these authors were often far superior to those of many researchers in later years, although they were certainly not free of the Orientalist discourses of their time. Caroe (1990 [1958]), a distinguished and dedicated servant of the British Raj, offers an illustrative example of colonial rhetoric when he compares two related tribes from what is today the Afghan-Pakistan border: "The nearest I can go to it is to liken the Mahsud to a wolf, the Wazir to a panther. Both are splendid creatures; the panther is slier, sleeker and has more grace, the wolf-pack is more purposeful, more united and more dangerous" (p. 393). His account of these groups as if they were wild beasts combines fascination, naturalization, and even homo-eroticization, with an underlying concern for control and surveillance.

Although the diplomatic isolation of Afghanistan in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries was in large part the result of British policy, this colonial body of literature constructed the romantic representation of an unruly and remote region cut off from the outside world, a trope that remains influential even now. Indeed, the image of an insular, isolated land where change can be brought about only if induced from outside continues to pervade many policy reports and even scholarly works (for a discussion on how the scholarship on Islam among the Pashtuns presents such biases, see Caron 2007).

In most journalistic accounts but also some scholarly works (Barry 1984), Afghanistan still epitomizes the historical resistance to external powers making it the eternal "graveyard of empires," to use the well-known cliché that has been cogently criticized and contextualized. Indeed the region was more of a "highway of conquest" (Barfield 2004, 2010) until the mid-nineteenth century, when a modern Afghanistan polity emerged as a result of the actions of the British and Russian governments (on the colonial encounter, see Edwards 1989). Only then was the very name of the country assigned and its present territory carved out (Hanifi 2011, Noelle 1997). Afghanistan was not immune from British influence during the nineteenth century in spite of the largely inconclusive military ventures of the two Anglo-Afghan wars of 1839–1842 and 1878–1880. During his reign (1880–1901), Abdur Rahman broke down internal resistance and built a relatively strong state thanks to foreign subsidies and, more generally, to the country's integration into the colonial markets as a periphery of global capitalism (Hanifi 2011). Following its full diplomatic independence after the third Anglo-Afghan war in 1919, far from being isolated once again, the country formed a unique transnational sphere and was well connected both with the neighboring regions and with the development of Muslim modernism in India. Moreover, as an independent country Afghanistan was a space of "projected idealism" (Green 2011, p. 483) for many Muslims engaged in anticolonial struggles throughout South Asia and the Middle East. The

border region with today's Pakistan, in particular, often represented as an enclave of violence and lawlessness, is, and has been, a space open to the outside world, inhabited by a diversity of people who have been mobile, crossing borders continuously for political or economic reasons (Marsden & Hopkins 2011, Nichols 2008). In view of this pattern of cross-border exchanges and circulation (for cosmopolitanism in the preceding centuries, see Green 2008) both historians and anthropologists have debunked the representation of Afghanistan as intellectually and economically isolated.

THE ARRIVAL OF ANTHROPOLOGISTS IN THE MID-TWENTIETH CENTURY

Anthropologists came relatively late to the study of Afghanistan. Not until well after World War II did the first trained social scientists begin to conduct research in the country. Dupree (1980 [1973]), an archaeologist and anthropologist who spent many years in the country, mentored in the 1960s and 1970s an active generation of scholars. Several Afghan anthropologists such as A. Ghani, M.J. Hanifi, and M.N. Shahrani were trained and made their careers in Western universities.

In spite of Afghanistan's historical linkage with South Asia, regional studies on this area were geared predominantly toward the Middle East, with a focus on topics such as pastoral nomadism, state and tribe, honor and shame (Anderson 1975, Barfield 1981, Ferdinand 2006, Ghani 1978, Glatzer 1977, Tapper 1973). Discussions on political organization and kinship including the segmentary lineage system, transposed from Africanist anthropology, were the primary models by which anthropologists of Afghanistan engaged with general theories and other regional traditions. Whereas some studies analyzed the relationships between nomads and sedentary farmers (Ferdinand 1962), Tapper's (1983) edited volume stressed the social, political, and ecological-economic heterogeneity of the groups labeled as tribes, many of whom were not pastoral nomads. It also argued that tribal groups should not be represented as an archaic heritage from the past but understood in light of their historical interdependence with the state. Other themes included dispute settlement (Ghani 1987, Jones 1974); food (Centlivres 1985, Tapper & Tapper 1986); art, craft, and music (Klimburg 1999, Sakata 2002); vernacular architecture (Szabo & Barfield 1991); the history, social ecology, and political status of minority groups (Canfield 1973a,b; Edwards 1986a, Mousavi 1998, Shahrani 2002a); or emotion and the self (Anderson 1985, Canfield 1976, Grima 1993). Several works addressed issues of social organization and power, be they through the *buzkashi*, a game during which horsemen struggle over a headless calf or goat carcass (Azoy 1982); through storytelling (Mills 1991); or through life histories of exemplary figures from the past and present (Edwards 1996, 2002).

Two themes that have garnered recent attention had already been explored in the 1960s and 1970s: ethnicity and gender. The discussion of ethnicity was heavily influenced by the seminal work of Barth (1969) and his critique of substantivist concepts of identity (for appraisals of his contribution and legacy, see Edwards 1998, Marsden & Hopkins 2013). He argued that cultural differences are not produced in isolation but through interaction; ethnic groups should thus be seen as categories of ascription and identification that are constructed by the actors themselves. In Barth's view, therefore, scholars need to study the genesis of ethnic boundaries instead of proposing an inventory of objective features of groups (on the debate, see Digard 1988). Such an interactionist perspective on identity helps to account for the clear but evolving correlation existing among spatial distribution, ethnic identity, and religious affiliation. In east-central Afghanistan, for instance, Sunnis dominate areas that are more closely integrated into the national market. By contrast, religious heterodox groups tend to inhabit the more peripheral areas, with a cleavage between Ismaili and Twelver Shiites in places where the economy depends on rain-fed agriculture,

which requires little cooperation between neighbors (Canfield 1973a,b; see also Canfield 1978, Centlivres & Centlivres-Demont 1988b).

Gender, another topic that is often studied today, had already been addressed in the 1960s and 1970s. Anthropologists documented the complexity of relations between men and women with reference to alliance and the concepts of honor and shame (see Anderson 1982a,b, Christensen 1982, Ferdinand 1982, Kopecky 1982, Olesen 1982, Tapper & Tapper 1982). Marriage patterns of the Northern Tier of the Middle East (which corresponds roughly to regions where Iranian and Turkic languages are spoken) differ from those of the Arab World. In the latter, for instance in North Africa, women remain under the primary responsibility and protection of their male agnates after marriage. In the former, and more typically in Afghanistan, a woman's transfer to her new family is more final; divorce is rare and considered shameful. A man's honor and reputation are defined by the conduct of his mother, unmarried sisters and daughters, as well as his wife (Tapper & Tapper 1992/1993). Women have, therefore, a "subversive" power because their behavior reflects on male relatives' social status and prestige (Tapper 1991).

In the 1960s and 1970s, scholarship was limited on topics such as the state and its bureaucracy; elites and the urban space; bazaar and trade; shopkeepers and artisans (for a notable exception, see Centlivres 1970); and patterns of migration to lowlands, cities, or foreign countries. With its emphasis on tribal organization and pastoral nomadism, Street (1990) argued that the ethnography of Afghanistan, but also of Iran and Pakistan, was not totally immune from the vision of fossilized societies that characterized earlier Orientalist discourses. It lacked perhaps a conceptual core of its own—such as stratification and caste as in India or politics and exchange as in Papua New Guinea—to contribute significantly to key theoretical debates in the discipline.

THE ANTI-SOVIET JIHAD, FORCED DISPLACEMENT, AND THE SOCIAL SCIENCES

In the wake of the Communist coup of 1978, the Soviet intervention of 1979, and the ensuing civil war, opportunities for long-term ethnographic fieldwork in Afghanistan were temporarily suspended. Instead, accounts by Western journalists, who traveled within the country with resistance groups, and geopolitical analyses of the Afghan conflict by Western foreign policy analysts dominated the scene. Fieldwork carried out during the 1960s and 1970s, when Afghanistan was more accessible, continued to bear fruit in publications in the following two decades. However, lack of access to the field compelled social scientists to shift their focus, forcing them to redefine their objects of study and rethink their methodological approach. Studies dealt, for example, with the social, cultural, and political dimensions of Islamic militancy, topics little explored previously (on Islam and politics in general, see Olesen 1995; on printing and the production of pamphlets by resistance groups, see Edwards 1993, 1995; on violence, see Centlivres 1997).

But one of the most significant contributions of scholarship on Afghanistan to the development of social science in general was the impetus it gave to the emergence and institutionalization of the field of refugee studies (evidenced by the creation of the Refugee Studies Center at the University of Oxford in 1982), which transcended conventional disciplinary boundaries. Many anthropologists conducted research among Afghan refugees in the camps but also in the urban centers of Pakistan; they became interlocutors of international organizations and actively engaged in debates with colleagues working elsewhere in the world (Ahmed 1986, Boesen 1986, Centlivres & Centlivres-Demont 1988a, Connor 1989, Edwards 1986b, Shahrani 1995). Their work documented, in addition to the massive scale and problems of the flight itself, the way displaced people defined themselves in exile and dealt with aid provided by IOs and NGOs, an experience that was new for most Afghans. Afghans in Pakistan negotiated their collective identity around three poles

(Centlivres 1988). First, the international figure of the refugee enshrined in the 1951 United Nations Refugee Convention as a person who needs legal protection and socioeconomic assistance by the international community. To receive food rations and benefits from health and education services, Afghans quickly learned that they should not hide signs of distress but present themselves as victims. The second dimension related to the construction of identity around a specific Islamic discourse. By leaving their country ruled by an impious Communist government to flee to Pakistan, many Afghans likened their situation to the Prophet Muhammad's migration from Mecca to Medina. In this way, refugees were not victims in need of international compassion but instead were people actively willing to brave all dangers for the sake of their faith. The third aspect was the Pashtun tribal code, according to which some Afghans represented themselves as struggling against a more powerful enemy and taking temporary refuge among fellow tribesmen on the other side of an international border, which they did not perceive as a social or cultural boundary.

Over time, Afghans developed very effective transnational networks based on their continued mobility and the dispersion of kin group members. One of the most striking aspects of these networks is the huge flow of remittances to Afghanistan. Migration in the Afghan context, with a long history of cross-border movement, can be seen not simply as a response to war and insecurity, but also as an efficient economic strategy for households, in effect blurring the boundaries between refugees and voluntary migrants (Monsutti 2004, 2005). Seen through a transnational prism, Afghan patterns of mobilities showed that migration is not a linear movement between a point of departure and a point of arrival but is instead a complex circulation between two or more locations that form an integrated social system. By contrast, the three solutions to the refugee problem promoted by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)—repatriation in the country of origin, integration in the country of first asylum, resettlement in a third country—all seek to end the cross-border movement of people (Monsutti 2008a; for a critical appraisal of the massive repatriation campaign supported by the UNHCR after the fall of the Taliban, see Turton & Marsden 2002).

Owing to problems of access, Afghan refugees in Iran were largely understudied in the 1980s compared with those in Pakistan. The first series of studies documented the difference between the male individual migrants, who were integrated in the national labor market in Iran, and the Afghan families, who increasingly faced administrative hurdles (Adelkhah & Olszewska 2007, Monsutti 2007, Olszewska 2007, Tober 2007). Gradually, a number of researchers began to study Afghan migrants in Europe, North America, and Australia, highlighting the persistence of transnational ties and the uneasy adjustment of the refugees to the new environment (Omidian & Lipson 1992, Shalinsky 1996).

This period, during which it was nearly impossible to conduct research within the country, paradoxically opened up new perspectives for the anthropology of Afghanistan. Edwards (1994), for example, initially expressed his dismay at having to abandon his original plan to work in a bounded community, whether a mountain village or a nomadic group. He was forced by circumstances to do research in a variety of places he had not anticipated: in refugee camps in Pakistan, among Afghans in the United States, or on the Internet. Reflecting a broader shift in the discipline as a whole, his fieldwork connected a multiplicity of sites (from Peshawar to Washington) as well as the virtual sphere of the Internet.

ACADEMIC SCRAMBLE FOR AFGHANISTAN: BETWEEN CONSULTANCY AND EMBEDDED ANTHROPOLOGY

Only a few researchers conducted extensive fieldwork within Afghanistan in the 1990s (Giustozzi 2000, Monsutti 2005). But a striking characteristic of the early years of the 2000s is the presence

of researchers pursuing Masters degrees or PhDs while working for humanitarian or development organizations proposing guidelines to reconstruct the war-torn country.

Since the fall of the Taliban regime, consulting and policy analysis have boomed in Kabul. Anthropologists increasingly interact with development professionals, who see their task as bringing about social change. The diversity of locations from which ethnography is produced today in the country thus reflects the progressive blurring of the boundary between academic and applied research. The state of disarray of national institutions of higher education after several decades of conflict along with the demand for immediately applicable knowledge have hindered the development of independent social sciences in Afghanistan. Many Kabul-based and internationally funded research institutions aim to improve policy and programs through their reports addressing migration and displacement, urban and rural livelihood, health and education, gender, governance and security, tribalism, justice and the rule of law, environment, and land and resources. Given growing concerns regarding security, many regions are increasingly out of bounds for anthropologists working on their own. Instead aid and policy institutions provide jobs to young researchers, serve as meeting points for more senior scholars, and offer access and logistical support to all kinds of social scientists. The agendas and terminology of UN agencies, international NGOs, governmental bodies, and armed forces have thus come to percolate the entire political economy of research in Afghanistan.

Despite several in-depth analyses of political developments having been published since the 1980s (Dorronsoro 2000; Giustozzi 2000, 2007, 2009a,b; Maley 2002; Rashid 2002; Roy 1985; Rubin 1995), the ever-growing literature on development, peace-building, and insurgency has been dominated by short-term policy interests. Reminiscent of the empirical positivism of the colonial gazetteers, the latter tends to hover between an uncritical resurgence of modernization theory and a somewhat naïve valorization of the local, just as it is poised uneasily between a state-centric view and an idealization of participatory democracy. The older themes of ethnicity and tribalism have received a new lease of life. Major players in the governance of Afghanistan have adopted an ethnic and tribal interpretation of local society and thus of the conflict. Such practice carries with it the risk of reifying identities and conflating tribal belonging with political affiliation (for one illustration, see the Program for Culture and Conflict Studies of the Naval Postgraduate School in Monterey, California: <http://www.nps.edu/Programs/CCS/index.html>). It is oblivious to the scholarship showing the need to situate ethnicity in the context of the emergence of the nation-state so that political mobilization along ethnic lines can be understood as a consequence rather than as a cause of the conflict (Schetter 2003, 2005; Harpviken 1996; and see Tapper 2008, who describes how self-designation among nomads has evolved in contact with IOs and NGOs). In an unpredictable and insecure environment, people forge temporary alliances to secure and distribute resources as social, political, and economic opportunities change. Members of descent and ethnic groups strategically diversify their political ties to various factions to ensure that some kin are always on the winning side (Monsutti 2008b).

Besides attracting social scientists as consultants, a common situation worldwide, Afghanistan became the locus for anthropologists embedded in military units deployed on the ground. The Human Terrain System (HTS) was developed by the US Army following its intervention in Afghanistan (2001) and Iraq (2003) to improve its understanding of the local social organization and to enhance counterinsurgency effectiveness. The first social scientists were deployed in early 2007 with military units in Afghanistan. This initiative provoked considerable controversy. The Executive Board of the American Anthropological Association (AAA) convened in summer 2006 an ad hoc Commission on the Engagement of Anthropology with the US Security and Intelligence Communities. Its statement in October 2007 and final report two years later raised serious ethical concerns while stating that anthropologists embedded in the HTS could not follow the norms

stipulated in the AAA Code of Ethics. First, their activities were seen as incompatible with the founding principle to do no harm to the people they study, bearing in mind that the information collected was used to conduct counterinsurgency. Second, their activities were considered to breach the responsibility to scholarship. The AAA Commission and Executive Board were concerned that embedded anthropologists may compromise the security of other social scientists by blurring research and military action and creating a confusion in the perceptions of the local populations. In contrast with this ethical critique, others linked to the aid community adopted a more pragmatic stance. They argued that the HTS was effective neither in collecting useful data for the military nor in winning hearts and minds. Ultimately, its contribution to counterinsurgency and stabilization was far from proven (Fishstein & Wilder 2012).

The debate on the HTS is ongoing. Embedded social scientists continue to insist on the benefit of their work (McFate & Fondacaro 2011), whereas their opponents, who have formed the Network of Concerned Anthropologists, have published a counter-counterinsurgency manual (2009). Anthropologists with considerable research experience in Afghanistan did not hesitate to participate in the debate on the reconstruction and nation-building project (e.g., Barfield 2011, Barfield & Nojumi 2010, Shahrani 2002b) but have been relatively silent on the specific issue of the HTS. One notable exception is Edwards (2010), who takes the HTS as an object of ethnographic inquiry that deserves study in its own right. As a result of this controversy, anthropologists have been compelled to confront the broader significance of their work and to take positions in public debates.

In the Afghan context, the question is not how anthropology might inform development projects but rather how the humanitarian and development industry influences the discipline. The way ethnographic research is conducted in the country today should prompt us to examine how engagement with humanitarian aid, postconflict reconstruction, and even counterinsurgency affect anthropological practice as well as theory. Nowhere does the politics of doing anthropology today appear more explicitly a matter of debate than in Afghanistan. In an environment saturated with humanitarian and development projects, aid money, donor competition, and military insecurity, there is serious need of critical reflexivity on the ethics and practice of anthropological knowledge production. Social scientists are part of the apparatus to deliver aid and promote a top-down, state-centric, and market-driven concept of peace-building. How does this positioning affect intellectual autonomy? Anthropologists tend to be perceived as humanitarian aid workers or agents of development by the people among whom they intend to do fieldwork. In what ways is their work incorporated into local people's strategies to improve their own lives and livelihood?

THE GRADUAL EMERGENCE OF NEW PERSPECTIVES

The donor-driven policy literature has clear conceptual biases and poses serious ethical concerns; it tends to ignore current theoretical debates on postcolonialism, subaltern studies, and globalization. However, its emphasis on social change and capacity building paradoxically offers the opportunity to explore an alternative to the romantic attraction of pastoral nomadic livelihoods prevailing in prewar anthropological scholarship, on the one hand, and the radical critique of humanitarian and development discourses as an instrument of control over unruly peripheral regions, on the other. The Afghan context is pervaded by power relations that cannot be described in terms of mere tribal traditions or alien values imposed on local populations. Any analysis of Afghanistan as an open political arena with profound—and often violent—confrontations over social and political contracts needs to transcend the opposition between an opportunistic acceptance of, or fierce resistance against, foreign models. The current reconstruction effort, with its humanitarian,

development, judicial, and military facets, is more than a vector of hegemony; it expresses a key feature of how governance and power operate in the postcolonial world.

Gender relations have become a much-discussed subject in the wake of the international intervention to promote democracy and human rights. Amid the voluminous literature assessing the conditions under which gender mainstreaming can be carried out, there exist a few studies that epitomize what form an anthropological examination of the international involvement in Afghanistan can take while engaging with wider disciplinary debates. Feminist scholarship has unveiled some of the ethical issues underlying the War on Terror, showing that the continual victimization of Muslim women reifies cultures and serves political and military purposes (Abu-Lughod 2002). As former US First Lady Laura Bush stated a few weeks after the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks, “[C]ivilized people throughout the world are speaking out in horror, not only because our hearts break for the women and children in Afghanistan but also because, in Afghanistan, we see the world the terrorists would like to impose on the rest of us” (Bush 2001; also mentioned in Abu-Lughod 2002, p. 784). The image of the Islamic fundamentalist and his female victim iterated, to recast a famous formulation by Gayatri Spivak, the old colonial trope of Western men—and also women in this case—saving Muslim women from Muslim men. The risk is to denounce the Taliban while remaining uncritical toward US foreign policy, ultimately contributing to the legitimization of military intervention (Hirschkind & Mahmood 2002).

IOs and NGOs are obsessed with the reform of an oppressive patriarchal system, as if the most serious problems faced by Afghan women were Afghan men. Aid projects such as widow-run bakeries in Kabul show little understanding of the local context, where both men and women face the social consequences of war and political violence. Largely unaware of the suffering, hopes, and desires of the persons meant to be assisted, these well-intentioned initiatives may end by denying agency to Afghan women and exacerbating both individual suffering and social tensions (Daulatzai 2006; on gender issues, see also Billaud 2009, 2012; Kandiyoti 2007). Such scholarship on women’s empowerment programs can be situated within a growing body of research on the way the long-lasting presence of humanitarian and development organizations transform individual subjectivities, collective identities, and everyday social relations. Some scholars but also several practitioners in humanitarian aid and development organizations have expressed strong reservations on the outcomes of the reconstruction efforts (Benelli et al. 2012; Centlivres & Centlivres-Demont 1999; Donini 2007, 2012; Donini et al. 2004; Goodhand 2002; Goodhand & Sedra 2010; Maley 2006; Rubin 2005; Suhrke 2007, 2011; Tadjbakhsh & Schoiswohl 2008; Wimmer & Schetter 2003). These works resonate with the general critique of humanitarian aid, development, and transnational governmentality that has grown since the end of the Cold War. It addresses the tension between the pervasiveness of the nation-state as the organizational entity of today’s international politics and the emergence of overlapping sovereignties linked to the global action of IOs and NGOs, the military, and armed militant networks (Hansen & Stepputat 2006, Randeria 2007). The social life of humanitarian and development workers—expatriates and local staff—also constitutes an emerging field of study to which the experience of Afghanistan could be a valuable contribution.

Let us consider the example of the National Solidarity Program (NSP), the main rural rehabilitation project under way in Afghanistan. Launched in 2003, funded primarily by the World Bank, administered by the Afghan ministry of development, and implemented by NGOs, this project is celebrated by the various stakeholders as the success story of the reconstruction effort. Its objective is to distribute funds directly to the rural people and establish democratically elected local councils, which are to plan and manage development. Several unpublished MA theses and PhD dissertations in Western universities as well as many commissioned studies have been produced with the intention to improve the project’s effectiveness. But one can also study the NSP in its

own right to examine how humanitarian aid and development projects are transforming Afghan society. The NSP is one element of a much larger conceptual and bureaucratic apparatus to promote new forms of transnational governmentality, which coexist with, and sometimes challenge, the more familiar territorialized expressions of state power and sovereignty (Monsutti 2012).

The practices of humanitarian and development organizations have now become part of the intricacies of local power struggles. The town of Istalif, north of Kabul, for instance (as described by Coburn 2011), remained relatively free of violence in the years following the fall of the Taliban while the country as a whole faced growing insecurity. Each political faction in the town worked to undermine its rivals without directly confronting them. Such a strategy of “masterly inactivity” (according to Coburn’s expression) helps explain the failure of many reconstruction projects, which would bring shared benefit to the population but, at the same time, upset the fragile balance of power between factions. Unpredictability thus may lead to resistance to social change but also to a decrease of violence, the consequences of which are considered by all to be too risky.

The transformation of social organization and power structures in the country can be contextualized in the *longue durée*. One can see recurrent patterns across the three Anglo-Afghan wars, the Soviet war, and the subsequent internecine conflict for power, which could inform our understanding of the current situation. But it is important to recall that the legitimization and balance of power within Afghan society were irremediably transformed in the nineteenth century, when the rulers of Kabul mobilized rural and tribal populations to resist the British militarily, undermining indirectly the long-term authority of the center (Barfield 2010). In a sense, the “unruliness” attributed to Afghanistan can be conceived of as a historical product of the colonial encounter (on past and present political structures, see also Centlivres & Centlivres-Demont 2000, Crews & Tarzi 2008, Hanifi 2004, Saikal 2004, Schetter 2013, Shahrani & Canfield 1984).

Considering the large number of Afghans living outside their country of origin today, recent scholarship continues to be concerned with migration both within the region and increasingly to the West (Baily 2010, Bathaie 2011, Chatty 2010, Harpviken 2009, Monsutti 2009, Schmeidl & Maley 2008). Topics discussed range from the refugee regime, bridging the gap between studies on migration and international institutions (Scalettaris 2007), to the involvement of the Afghan diaspora in the reconstruction of the country (Oeppen 2010). Emerging research themes include legal anthropology and the rule of law (Barfield 2008, De Lauri 2011), conflicts over land (Adelkhah 2013), the media (Kamal 2007, Skuse & Gillespie 2011), literature and poetry (Green & Arbabzadah 2013, Olszewska 2007, Strick van Linschoten & Kuehn 2012), as well as suffering and mental illness (Eggerman & Panter-Brick 2010, Panter-Brick et al. 2009). The political economy of opium and narcotics has also been scrutinized, although not by anthropologists (Goodhand 2005, Kreutzmann 2007, Rubin & Sherman 2008).

CONCLUSION: THE SIGNIFICANCE OF ANTHROPOLOGY FOR AFGHANISTAN AND OF AFGHANISTAN FOR ANTHROPOLOGY

Afghanistan is a critical location from which to reflect on the potentials and challenges of anthropology. The country illustrates perhaps in their starkest expression social, economic, and political processes elsewhere in Asia, Africa, and Latin America, but increasingly also in Europe and North America: social and political violence; terrorism; unregulated markets; migration and transnational networks; and overlapping sovereignties between the state and nonstate actors. Humanitarian aid, development projects, and also social science research are part of people’s everyday lives and the cognitive landscape in Afghanistan. As such, they may be understood as categories of practice that are not just imported from outside but are interpreted and reinterpreted,

produced and reproduced, in a complex dynamic spanning individual subjectivities, local social relations, national power games, and global designs.

The reconstruction efforts promoted by IOs, NGOs, and foreign governments participating in the military coalition, which aim to build liberal institutions and emancipate people from the straitjacket of tradition, are imbued by specific concepts of state and society. Two arguments are heard repeatedly among international experts in Kabul. First is the “not yet” rhetoric: Afghanistan is not yet ready for democracy, owing to the low literacy rate, religious conservatism, unequal gender relations, rampant corruption, and the pervasiveness of the drug economy. Second is the argument about the negative role of warlords and insurgents, who are conceptualized as being external to the local populations: Progressive elites, often from the diaspora, attempt to rebuild the country but meet the resistance of the jihadists and the Taliban, who are derailing the process.

One can see an element of continuity between this discourse and colonial tropes. But the current situation does not merely replicate the old Great Game. International relations have changed and are no longer shaped by a struggle between competing colonial empires or opposing blocs. A formal homogenization has taken place in the political topography. Sovereign states, equal in terms of rights, cover the entire globe. But these disparate states not only vary greatly in revenue and military capacity but also coexist with nonstate actors, who deliver services.

Anthropology—more than other social sciences—may be in a better position to complicate the linear discourse of modernization. The case of Afghanistan points to the need to go beyond the idea of multiple modernities, which unfold in parallel following different historical and cultural patterns (Eisenstadt 2000), in favor of the idea of entangled modernities, whereby past and present European political, economic, and intellectual developments can be understood only in a relational perspective as a complex process of interactions with other regions of the world (Randeria 2006). Being at the vanguard of some contemporary processes, Afghanistan may well play a role similar to that of Africa in the argument advanced by Jean and John Comaroff (2012) by helping to overturn the geographies and chronologies of core and periphery so that the so-called South, often the first to feel the effects of global forces, may prefigure the future of the North.

Whereas international observers systematically deride as archaic any resistance to their plans, large sections of the Afghan society apparently do not aspire to the future designed for them by the promoters of liberal peace (see the critique of human rights and democracy conveyed in the poetry of the Taliban in Strick van Linschoten & Kuehn 2012). The Afghan case may perhaps teach us to think about the world without the teleological narrative of modernization. For contrary to colonial and postcolonial representations of an inward-looking society, Afghanistan has been for centuries integrated in regional networks of trade and intellectual exchange. Today, the country may be a key site from which to address some of the moral and epistemological challenges faced by anthropologists in the early twenty-first century, such as cooperation with, or working within, IOs and NGOs or the military; a critique of the concept of social groups as discrete units rooted in a particular territory; or the existence of overlapping sovereignties between a variety of actors within and beyond the nation-state.

The anthropology of Afghanistan has been transformed by the disruption of war and forced displacement. Mirroring general developments in the discipline, the focus of anthropological research has shifted away from pastoralism and identity, from a narrow correlation between social life and territory, to the study of translocal phenomena. Developments in Afghanistan may prefigure larger shifts in governance, sovereignties, and population mobilities; they may further a fine-grained understanding of the local in its coextensiveness with the global. They may well compel anthropologists to actively engage in public debates across the increasingly blurred boundaries

between academic and policy literature. We still have a long way to go to deprovincialize not only Afghanistan but also anthropology.

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